

Chapter 85-1 - Escape

The Emei Thorns excitedly returned to her fingertip. Baili Shiqi, who had followed behind, waved out an ice-blue light that knocked the other dumbstruck immortal general to the ground.

"Sorry, sorry." Baili Shiqi's cloud-like hair flew as she retreated to Ning Fuyi's side, continuously bowing and apologizing to the two who had fainted on the ground.

"You've been apologizing all the way since entering the dungeon," Ning Fuyi said, now forcing herself to be alert, her voice still hoarse as she adjusted Jiuying's body higher on her back.

"The way of jianghu righteousness states that attacking one's own kind is the most unrighteous act," Baili Shiqi explained with her small face flushed red.

As soon as she finished speaking, she struck out with a palm, sending an immortal soldier who was chasing them through the door flying out.

"Sorry, sorry." She pressed her palms together with a tearful expression.

Ning Fuyi shook her head despite her aching eyes, but suddenly felt a stinging pain at the back of her neck, so she turned around: "Jiuying, your tears are about to burn me to death!"

"When did I have tears? Don't speak nonsense." Jiuying raised her hand to dispel the flames in her eyes, saying weakly. She had been tortured for several days and was already physically and mentally exhausted, nearly falling for that immortal general's psychological attack.

She had to admit that she had been afraid just now - afraid that Ning Fuyi was another Chidu¹, afraid that she had been deceived of her sincere heart once again.

"Don't worry, I'm nothing like that villain Chidu. Since we are already bound by life and death, even if I die, I, Ning Fuyi, will never abandon you," Ning Fuyi knew what was in her heart and said gently.

"Hmph." Jiuying snorted, but her arms gripping Ning Fuyi's shoulders tightened.

"More immortal soldiers are coming," Jiuying said quietly, though severely injured, her divine beast senses remained sharp. "About a hundred people. You two can't handle them. Just leave me here..."

"No problem. Since I brought Sister Ning in, I naturally know how to get out," Baili Shiqi's starry eyes sparkled as she grabbed Ning Fuyi's arm. "Follow me!"

Since Jiuying was injured and couldn't enter the thought bead, Ning Fuyi could only struggle to carry Jiuying as they ran through Wangyuan Dungeon. The footsteps of immortal soldiers grew closer, but all around were fiend purgatories. Not to mention an exit - they couldn't even see a proper door.

"Who is this person? Why is she helping us?" Jiuying's weak voice rang in her mind.

"Her name is Baili Shiqi. She's a friend I met in the mortal realm, and she's from Penglai," Ning Fuyi answered.

"A Penglai person? All of Penglai are wolf-hearted, dog-lunged scoundrels. How do you know she's trustworthy?" Jiuying said.

Before Ning Fuyi could answer, Baili Shiqi suddenly stopped in front of an ancient stone door. The door was scalding to the touch, and it seemed like something was trapped behind it, making people feel afraid just by approaching.

Baili Shiqi raised her hand and shook the chain of magical artifacts in her hand. Several streams of ice-blue light flowed into the stone door, and suddenly a small door opened in the corner - just big enough for one person to crawl through while bending over.

"Quickly!" Baili Shiqi bent down and went in.

Ning Fuyi looked back at the immortal soldiers who were about to catch up, hesitated no more, put Jiuying down, helped her crawl through the small door. After the two of them entered, the small door instantly disappeared.

The immortal soldiers behind them, panting heavily, all stopped when they reached this place. The leading immortal general wiped sweat from his forehead and steadied his helmet: "Damn it, where did this demon creature run off to!"

"General, this is where the demon beast Xiangliu² is imprisoned. We cannot stay long! That demon creature must have escaped through another route!" An immortal soldier hurriedly cupped his hands.

The immortal general was so angry his helmet tilted several times, and he straightened it irritably: "What are you all still doing here! Quickly go seal off the entire Wangyuan Dungeon, don't let even a trace of aura escape! That demon creature is under the Emperor's orders to be captured. If we let her escape like this, neither you nor I can bear the consequences!"

"The Canghai Tower³ is the most impregnable. Even ancient fierce beasts cannot escape from it. How could a small demon creature escape like this? There must be inside help! Quickly go report to Lord Wen Yao⁴, ask Lord Wen Yao to report to the Emperor, send more people, search all of Penglai!"

Several subordinate immortal soldiers quickly responded and led the others away.

Meanwhile, inside the stone door, Ning Fuyi was standing in a cloud of black smoke, face to face with a gigantic nine-headed black serpent.

This black serpent was missing one eye, and its remaining seventeen fist-sized eyes were all staring at her. The scene was somewhat eerie.

"Xiangliu?" Jiuying said in surprise, covering her heart and leaning on Ning Fuyi.

The Emei Thorns in Ning Fuyi's hand spun excitedly. She pressed down the restless Emei Thorns and turned her head to ask: "You know it?"

Jiuying nodded and moved closer to Ning Fuyi: "I had the fortune of meeting it once tens of thousands of years ago. Do you see that missing eye?"

"I poked it out."

Ning Fuyi was speechless and held the Emei Thorns horizontally in front of her.

"Don't be afraid of them. It's called Baobao⁵, and it's not fierce at all!" Seeing them frozen in place, Baili Shiqi quickly blocked in front to explain, then gently called to the fierce beast and extended her hand.

The girl stood before the massive monster like this - it looked dangerous no matter how you looked at it. However, the next scene was shocking. The Xiangliu, full of fierce light, suddenly lowered its snake head and voluntarily rubbed against Baili Shiqi's palm, like a pleading puppy.

"When I was little, I playfully fell into the dungeon and learned then that this fierce beast actually has a gentle nature. It's just that Penglai people are taboo about fierce demons and view it as a flood or savage beast, absolutely forbidding me to approach," Baili Shiqi smiled.

"My goodness," Jiuying raised her hand delicately to her forehead. "The face of ancient fierce beasts has been completely lost."

Baili Shiqi happily petted Xiangliu's head a few times, her smile fading as she carefully turned around: "I can unlock the mystic locks on Xiangliu. Sister Ning, this Wangyuan Dungeon has no other exit. If you want to get out, you can only rely on Xiangliu."

"It's just..."

"It's just that if you really ride an ancient fierce beast to escape from Penglai, then your identity as a demon creature can never be discarded. From now on, you'll have no connection with the righteous path and can never return to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate," Jiuying took over Baili Shiqi's words and said seriously.

The dungeon fell silent for a moment. Both looked at Ning Fuyi.

They were all quite disheveled now. Jiuying was covered in wounds and blood stains, and Ning Fuyi was also weathered and injured to her core, her hair still stuck with dust and mud, dried blood on her cheeks.

Like cornered beasts at the end of their rope, abandoned by the six realms with nowhere left in heaven and earth to shelter.

"Righteous path, evil path - who gets to define them? Those reputations are just shackles the outside world places on my head. Why should I cower in fear because of a few words from the world?" Ning Fuyi spoke, raising her eyes despite her disheveled hair. "Before, I was forced into helplessness, confused and muddled. Now I'll be the demon they speak of myself."

With that, the woman suddenly leaped onto Xiangliu. Her black robes fluttered as she smiled wantonly.

"I want to see whether this heaven and earth will tolerate me."

Half an incense stick's time later, the originally peaceful Wangyuan Dungeon suddenly shook violently. Accompanied by countless hissing sounds from fiends and demon beasts, the nine-headed giant serpent burst through its shackles and soared into the sky.

The layers of array formations sealing the dungeon immediately collapsed. The immortal soldiers and generals guarding it were blown back repeatedly by the fierce wind, terrified beyond measure.

"What is that? What escaped?"

"It's a... a fierce beast! Quick! Quickly report to the Emperor!"

The long-absent fierce wind blew so hard they couldn't open their eyes. Wind rushed into their clothes, chillingly cold, but Ning Fuyi felt all the gloom around her body being blown away by the wind, actually feeling a floating sense of liberation.

She looked back at those immortal soldiers charging against the wind, joyfully wielding the Emei Thorns. Thus, a sheet of pink lightning swept through the air, and those immortal soldiers were like duckweed swept away by huge waves, screaming as they were swept into the fierce wind.

Perhaps due to the Emei Thorns' effect, and because she was accustomed to using lightning, she now felt her strength had greatly increased. Even with internal injuries, she could control her power freely. Feeling delighted, she simply summoned thunder and lightning from the clear sky, striking the immortal soldiers and generals until they screamed chaotically.

"Hahahaha, you bunch of sanctimonious bastard demi-gods, this old lady will show you today what a divine beast is!" Jiuying also stood up on Xiangliu's back despite her injuries, shouting joyfully as she raised her arms to summon balls of fierce fire.

The fierce fire fell into Penglai's temples and pavilions. Thus, the originally magnificent immortal realm was immediately turned upside down. Glazed tiles shattered completely, small bridges and flowing water were destroyed instantly, and countless Penglai people fled for their lives in the streets in chaos.

"Demon creatures, they really are demon creatures! Come quickly, go request Lord Zuoshi⁶!" Several immortal generals, burned until their faces were pitch black, shouted heartrendingly.

In the resplendent treasure hall surrounded by pearls and emeralds, incense smoke curled upward. On both sides of the great hall hung many magnificent embroideries depicting scenes from the six realms.

Even the curtains hanging from the ceiling were embroidered with mountains, rivers, and seas using cloud silk. If you looked carefully, they actually depicted all corners of the world.

A tall figure sat behind the curtains, their shadow cast on the curtains as they methodically threaded needles. Below in the hall stood several people, all with lowered heads, not daring to speak.

"Emperor, you suddenly fell seriously ill a few days ago and were unconscious until now when you just awoke. You should rest more," a female immortal said with lowered head.

That person didn't speak, and the others didn't dare say anything more.

At this moment, the quiet was suddenly broken. Several immortal soldiers stumbled into the great hall: "Emperor, Emperor, this is bad! That demon creature somehow escaped from Canghai Tower and even broke into Wangyuan Dungeon, rescuing the qilin and Xiangliu!"

Upon hearing this, the hall immediately erupted in chaos, while the figure behind the curtains suddenly stopped embroidering, sharply withdrawing their hand that had been pricked by the needle.

Footnotes:

1. **Chidu (赤都)**: An ancient god who betrayed Jiuying in the past, using her as a stepping stone to escape danger
2. **Xiangliu (相柳)**: A nine-headed serpent from Chinese mythology, considered an ancient fierce beast
3. **Canghai Tower (沧海塔)**: "Vast Sea Tower" - the prison where Ning Fuyi was held
4. **Lord Wen Yao (文曜君)**: A high-ranking official in Penglai
5. **Baobao (宝宝)**: "Baby/Treasure" - an endearing name Baili Shiqi gave to the fierce beast
6. **Lord Zuoshi (左使大人)**: "Left Envoy Lord" - another high-ranking official in Penglai